

Steps Forward for Sudan

The Munich Security Conference this past week offered some interesting insights into some large foreign policy issues. I watched a two-part talk about the Sudanese Civil War, which brought up some valuable considerations. The talk consisted of a moderated discussion with PM Kamil Idris of Sudan and a panel made up of US Senior Advisor Boulos, the British and German Foreign Secretaries, and a youth activist from Port Sudan. Here are my main takeaways:



PM Kamil Idris (left) at the Munich Security Conference, Feb 2026

1. The SAF cannot or is unwilling to directly identify their opposition.

When PM Idris was asked whether his government had been in communication with the RSF, he denied their existence, referring to their official disillusion in 2023, even though the group continues to operate today. While this may be a political ploy for Idris, who is in effect not giving the RSF the power of recognition, it also may be counterintuitive to negotiation. If the RSF's frustrations originated in the fact that they were second-in-command to the SAF, in the military junta which ousted al-Bashir, denying their existence outright is not likely to improve their willingness to negotiate. The moderator summed it up well, saying "if you don't know who your enemy is, who is there to make peace with?" The RSF doesn't need to be legitimized, but they need to be recognized as an actor, in order to have parties which can come to the negotiation table and represent both sides.

2. The complexities of secondary/tertiary actors in negotiation

One of the main bodies working towards a humanitarian ceasefire or negotiated end to this war is "The Quad" made up of the US, Egypt, UAE, and Sudan. While these parties express

that they're aiming to end violence, they each have their own individual interests in the region. Except for the US, these actors have each taken sides and have been supporting either the RSF (UAE) or SAF (Egypt, Saudi Arabia) throughout the war. These preferences limit either side's ability to be neutral in negotiation. They've created an environment where their opposition may be less willing to trust the negotiators to whom they aren't friendly. PM Idris expressed an unwillingness to negotiate with the UAE while they continued to supply weaponry to the RSF and it's likely that such apprehension could be extrapolated to the RSF's view of the SAF's supporters. Hence, the US will need to play an integral role in mediating this conflict, as a neutral tertiary stakeholder which has strong diplomatic relations with secondary parties on both sides of this conflict.

3. The extent of the humanitarian crisis

The humanitarian crisis in Sudan is far from being resolved and has only been exacerbated by the RSF's violent takeover of El Fasher in October 2025. Extreme violence has been committed by both sides in this conflict, with the US determining that the RSF committed genocide in El Fasher as well as recognizing war crimes committed by the SAF. British Foreign Secretary Yvonne Cooper highlighted gender-based violence being committed against women as they make their way to refugee camps. It's believed that a majority of women in these camps have experienced some type of sexual violence, as reported by a Sudanese psychologist who was counseling people in a camp near the border of Chad. Though there were only a few stories which were relayed during this panel, each one was harrowing.

So, what action items came out of these discussions?

The member of the Sudanese Youth Movement, Muhammad Rakman expressed that there have been a lot of conversations about Sudan over the past few years, but very little action. This conflict hasn't experienced the same international pressure that was felt during the war in Gaza, there is a sense of protraction in this civil war, but it should be within our power to end it. He reiterated the importance of a humanitarian ceasefire and the necessity of aid, which has been struggling to find its way to civilians. There is a sense that one of the numerous plans which have been proposed needs to be acted upon in a more concrete manner. The ideas have been presented, from here they should be modified as the negotiation process progresses.

The first step is to bring the parties to the table.